

THE FINAL HAND DRAFT 2

Written by

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1 **BLACK SCREEN**

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Silence.

Then—

A faint shuffling of cards.

Measured. Intentional.

FADE IN:

A spotlit card table, suspended in darkness. The light is already there. It has always been there. Faint lounge/bar noise drifts in. Low music. A lighter flicks. Glasses clink softly. No time of day. Just the table.

Details emerge:

The wood is worn, used for decades.

Faint moisture beads on the surface. Condensation.

A ring where a glass once sat. Long gone.

This table has seen things.

Clasped hands with a deck of cards in between enters frame.

Steady. Unrushed. High John.

Only now do we hear his voice. Quiet. Almost playful.

HIGH JOHN
"You ready?"

Someone unseen sits opposite him, leaning forward into the light. Arms come to rest on the table. High John pauses.

Then places a chip down on the table.

The game hasn't started.

But the outcome already exists.

CUT TO: THE BAR — EARLIER

Same lounge.

Wider now.

The Player sits at another table, mid-game with a Stranger.

His chip stack is thin.

Laughter. Loose energy.

The Player glances past the Stranger.

Across the room.

To the spotlight table.

High John sits alone.

Already present.

The Player watches a beat too long.

Smiles.

PLAYER
(chuckling, nods toward
High John)
I swear... some people just move
different. Like the room adjusts or
somethin'.

STRANGER
(looks over)
Adjusts how?

PLAYER
(smiles)
Like they're not rushin'. Not
lookin' around for permission.

The Stranger laughs.

The Player doesn't. He keeps watching High John.

PLAYER (CONT'D)
That's the kinda thing nobody ever
explains how to get.

Beat.

PLAYER (CONT'D)
(low, amused)

Like it's somethin' you're either born with... or shut out
of.

The Stranger studies him.

A small smile.

STRANGER

Maybe...Or maybe somebody
remembered to pass it on.

Cards shuffle.

The hand continues.

The Player loses.

The Stranger gathers the winnings calmly.

Then pauses.

STRANGER
You had that one.

PLAYER
Nah. Bad pull.

STRANGER
Wasn't the cards.

Beat.

PLAYER
What was it then?

STRANGER
You changed your mind twice before
you played it.

PLAYER
That's called thinkin'.

The Stranger smirks.

STRANGER
No. That's called not trustin'
what's already in your hand.

The Player scoffs.

STRANGER
Some folks spend so much time
lookin' for the next thing...they
miss the one they're holdin'.

Then pauses.

The Stranger reaches in his pocket and slides one chip back
across the table.

Not flashy.

Not generous.

Heavy.

The Player grabs it.

His thumb moves over the face of the chip.

Slow.

Curious.

An engraved rabbit.

Worn smooth from touch.

The chip subtly reflects the table light.

He smiles to himself.

Doesn't ask.

STRANGER

You ever play with the House?

PLAYER

House always wins.

STRANGER

Most folks sit with him once.

The Stranger keeps looking toward High John. Not fearful. Not reverent.

Like he's remembering something.

The Player follows his gaze.

PLAYER

And?

STRANGER

(smiles)

Depends what they came lookin' for.

A beat.

The Player turns the chip over again.

The rabbit catches the light.

STRANGER (CONT'D)

Funny thing about foxes.

PLAYER

What's that?

STRANGER

They spend so much time chasin' the
rabbit...they never notice who's
leadin' who.

A beat.

PLAYER

What's that supposed to mean?

The Stranger smiles.

Looks toward High John.

STRANGER

Depends what the fox thinks
he found.

The Player looks again toward the spotlight table.

High John hasn't moved.

Already waiting.

The Player stands.

Leaves the Stranger's table.

Crosses the room.

The bar noise dulls as he approaches the light.

He reaches the table.

Without asking.

Slides the chip forward.

High John looks up.

Eyes sharp.

Amused.

A low chuckle.

He says nothing.

Takes the chip and takes hold of it in his hand with the deck
of cards.

The Player sits opposite him.

A Bartender appears.

Unhurried.

Carrying a drink.

She sets it beside High John.

BARTENDER

The usual.

High John nods.

She turns to the Player.

A beat.

BARTENDER

You want anything?

PLAYER

I'm good.

The Bartender studies him.

Not judgment.

Recognition.

Like she's heard that answer before.

She leaves.

High John then throws the cards onto the table so they scatter. He washes the cards, gathers them, and riffle shuffles the cards on the table twice. Then a one handed cut of the cards.

He knocks on the deck.

knock, knock-knock, knock, knock...(pause)...knock, knock
(Shave and a Haircut two-bits tune)

Memory, not flair.

The knock lands. For a brief moment—

the lounge sound dips.

Not silence.

Just a pocket.

A glass stops rattling.

The music bends.

Across the room—

the Couple stop mid-conversation.

Completely still.

A beat.

The woman unconsciously taps her finger
against her glass.

knock.

knock-knock.

knock.

knock.

(pause)

knock.

knock.

She blinks.

Looks back to her husband.

Smiles.

Conversation resumes.

The Player watches.

Doesn't speak.

He clocks it.

HIGH JOHN

You ready?

The player leans forward into the light.

Forearms on the table.

High John pauses. Then sets the chip in the center of the
table.

The Player finally speaks

PLAYER
Its just Blackjack. Closest thing
to fair there is.

CUT TO: HIGH JOHN'S EYES

Still. Observant.

A flicker passes: recognition calculation something amused.

Truth and trick share the same breath.

Back to the table. High John says nothing.

He deals.

TITLES: THE DIAGNOSIS

One card to the Player.

Face down.

One card to High John.

Face down.(This is the dealer's first card.)

Silence stretches.

The Player fills it.

PLAYER (CONT'D)
I know how this works. Closer you
get to twenty-one, the better.
Simple math.

High John deals again.

Second card to the Player. Second to himself.(This is the
dealer's hole card)

All face down.

High John reaches over and turns the Player's first card.

10 of Hearts. (JOY / FULFILLMENT)

No comment.

He turns the second.

2 of Hearts. (UNION / BALANCE)

Twelve.

PLAYER (CONT'D)
That's solid. People overthink this
stuff. You just gotta know when to
move.

High John studies him. Says nothing.

He slides the deck forward.

The invitation is silent. The Player knocks the table. Two
fingers. Tries to keep it casual.

CUT TO:

Card flips.

5 of Hearts. (CHAOS OF LIFE / ENVY)

Seventeen.

The room subtly tightens.

A beat.

HIGH JOHN
You borrowed fire with wet hands.

Silence.

Not an ending, but a warning.

The Player doesn't hear it.

He hears challenge.

TITLES: THE TEMPTATION (false mastery)

CUT TO:

The player hits again.

Firmer.

Fingers linger near the chip.

CUT TO:

High John deals. Dealing a card from the deck.

CUT TO:

Card being placed down on the players side.

3 of Diamonds. (REACH / EXTRACTION)

Twenty.

Confidence spikes.

The player smiles.

PLAYER
I think I can hold it
(he pauses)
Just one more...

High John just gives the player a look and waits for the player to make a move.

TITLES: THE DAMNATION (soul bust)

No breath.

No space.

CUT TO:

The player hits again.

QUICK CUT TO:

High John deals. Dealing another card from the deck.

A beat.

CUT TO:

The card is slowly placed down in front of the player, revealing the card.

2 of Spades. (DEATH OF THE SPIRIT / DUALITY)

Bust.

A beat.

Something drains from the room.

The chip dulls.

Loses weight.

High John says nothing now.

He doesn't need to.

CUT TO:

TITLES: THE FINAL HAND

High John reaches to his own cards.

For the first time.

He turns over his first card. Jack of Diamonds. (THIEF / FALSE MASTERY)

He flips the hole card.

Ace of Spades.

Blackjack.

Twenty-one.

The Player exhales.

Laughs once.

Short.

Disbelieving.

PLAYER (CONT'D)

No— no, wait—

He stops himself and rubs his hands down his face aggressively.

The chip still sits where it was placed.

He Looks at the chip.

High John stands.

The light on the table dims to nothing.

The Player reaches for the chip.

He turns it in his fingers.

The engraving doesn't catch anymore.

Matte.

Flat.

All the cards vanish.

One card remains face up.

The Jack

A card meant to move.

Now stuck.

The Player stares at it. He knows now.

What it would have cost.

Too late.

The Player looks up at High John.

Waiting.

High John does not look back. He just looks down and adjusts his watch.

HIGH JOHN

The House doesn't take what isn't offered.

High John turns and walks away until he's out of focus.

The Player watches him go.

Then, slowly, he shifts.

Moves into High John's seat.

He brings his hands together. Clasps them.

As if something should be between them.

He knocks, knuckles hollow.

The motion is right.

The first knock lands.

He freezes.

Just a fraction too long.

Then continues—

knock.

knock, knock.

(pause)

knock, knock.

He knows it before it finishes. He missed it.

His jaw tightens.

He knocks again.

Faster.

Harder.

Wrong.

Then:

He stops.

Looks at his hands.

Like they betrayed him.

The table stays dead.

Nothing answers.

CUT TO:

BLACK

END